

RS 2,000-CRORE FETISH

The Government diverted funds from different departments for the construction of statues, parks and memorials

■ The construction of Ambedkar Memorial in Lucknow, earlier known as the Ambedkar Park, was taken up when Mayawati first became chief minister. It was completed in 2003. In May 2007, when she became the chief minister again, large parts of the memorial were demolished and reconstructed at a cost of Rs 150 crore.

■ Being built on the city's Jail Road, the Manyawar Kanshi Ram Memorial will cost the state exchequer Rs 370 crore. It boasts of the statues of BSP founder Kanshi Ram as well as Mayawati.

■ Construction for the Ramabai Ambedkar Rally Maidan began



THE HAND-BAG IS NOT TO BE MISSED IN THIS MAYAWATI STATUE IN ALAMBAGH

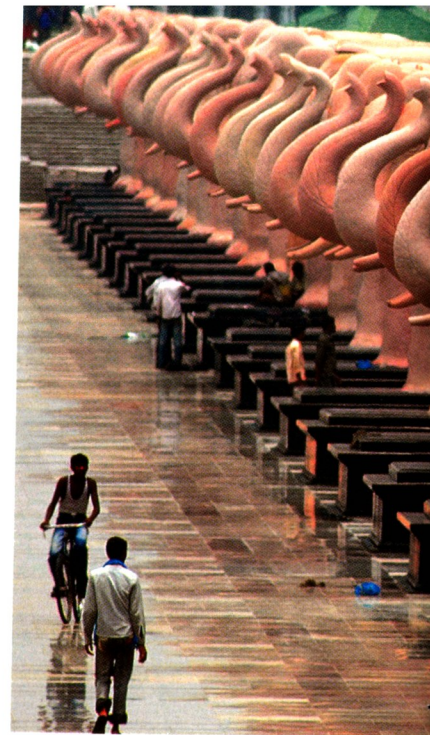
in August 2007. Spanning 51 acres, it is coming up on the Bijnore Road at a cost of Rs 65 crore.

■ Rs 90 crore have been allocated for the carving out of the Kanshi Ram Sanskritik Sthal of the 80-acre Smriti Upvan, which was built in the memory of the martyrs of Kargil. Statues of Mayawati and Kanshi Ram have been installed as well.

■ The Dr Bhimrao Ambedkar Samajik Parivartan Sthal, completed in April 2008, has cost the exchequer Rs 7 crore. Situated on the Gomti embankment on two acres of land, it too has the twin statues.

■ Spread over 6,000 sq m on the VIP Road in Alambagh, the Buddha Sthal will be constructed at an expenditure of Rs 90 crore. It will have a statue of Buddha under a canopy. There will be 100 stone columns, each with an elephant head.

■ An 18-acre park on the Kanpur Road called the Buddha Shanti Upvan will come at a cost of Rs 15.15 crore. Its work began in April and a marble statue of Buddha will be installed there.



RS 52 CRORE WERE SPENT ON STATUES OF ELEPHANTS, THE BSP PARTY SYMBOL; (RIGHT) HER INAUGURATION SPREE CONTINUES UNABATED

the state, all of which now lie buried. It is said that she had plans to create Mayavihar near Lucknow's Gomti Nagar.

Last week, the Supreme Court asked the state Government to explain what was termed as "the brazen misuse of public funds". The court directive followed a public interest litigation filed by lawyer Ravi Kant who took the RTI route to bring to the apex court's notice the wastage of nearly Rs 2,000 crore of public money "to falsely glorify the chief minister's fanciful whims and putting up statues of her". The rap on the knuckles from the court was accompanied by an opposition onslaught which saw a "Day of Mourning" (*Shok Diwas*) being observed across the state which was meant to highlight Mayawati's alleged misrule. Mulayam Singh Yadav, the former chief minister, declared that if voted back to power, the Samajwadi Party would have all statues and parks razed to the ground. The party's state unit chief Akhilesh Yadav accused the chief minister of destroying the cultural and architectural identity of Lucknow. "Like the Iraqis who pulled down Saddam's statues, the people of Lucknow would destroy these statues as